SEMPLICE ITALIAN KITCHEN | QUICK ITALIAN DINNERS

Pasta alla Cenere: 15-Minute Viral Italian "Ash Pasta"

with Gorgonzola & Black Olives

PREP: 5 mins | COOK: 10 mins | TOTAL: 15 mins | SERVINGS: 4 servings | CALORIES: 495 kcal

INGREDIENTS

* 400g (14 oz) Bronze-die Penne Rigate or Fusilli
* 200g (7 oz) Gorgonzola Dolce DOP (rinds removed, cut into chunks)
* 110g (3/4 cup) Pitted Italian Black Olives (Taggiasca or Leccino) (patted dry and finely minced into "ash")
* 45ml (3 tbsp) Whole Milk or Starchy Pasta Water (plus extra pasta water for tossing)
* 30g (1/3 cup) Parmigiano-Reggiano DOP (finely grated)
* 2 tbsp Fresh Flat-Leaf Parsley (finely minced (optional))
* 1 tsp Freshly Cracked Black Pepper

STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Boil the Pasta in Lightly Salted Water (9 mins)

Bring a pot of water to a rolling boil, salt moderately (since both Gorgonzola and olives are savory), and cook your penne or fusilli until 1 minute shy of al dente.

Step 2: Prepare the Black Olive "Ash" Tapenade (3 mins)

Pat the pitted black olives completely dry with paper towels. Using a sharp chef's knife (or rapid pulses in a mini food processor), chop the olives into tiny, uniform 1-2mm crumbles that look like dark volcanic ash. Divide into two portions: two-thirds for the sauce and one-third for the top garnish.

Step 3: Melt the Gorgonzola Dolce Gently (2 mins)

In a wide skillet over the lowest possible heat, combine the cubed Gorgonzola Dolce with 3 tablespoons of milk (or warm starchy pasta water). Stir gently with a wooden spoon for 2 minutes until melted into a smooth, velvety cream-never let it boil.

Step 4: Fold in the Pasta & Olive Ash (1 mins)

Transfer the al dente pasta directly into the melted Gorgonzola skillet along with two-thirds of the minced olive ash, the grated Parmigiano-Reggiano, and a splash of pasta water. Toss over low heat for 60 seconds until every piece is coated in a speckled, glossy sauce.

Step 5: Dust with Reserved Olive Ash & Serve (1 mins)

Plate immediately in warm bowls and scatter the reserved one-third dry olive "ash," freshly cracked black pepper, and minced parsley across the top for a dramatic visual finish.

NONNA'S CHEF TIPS:

- Patting the black olives dry before mincing keeps the final garnish fluffy and ash-like instead of wet or clumpy.
- If you can only find firmer blue cheese or Gorgonzola Piccante, whisk in 2 tablespoons of mascarpone or cream cheese to replicate the lush texture of Gorgonzola Dolce.